Why do transfers fail?

Luck, usage and chemistry in Big-5 football, per 90 minutes, 2014–2025

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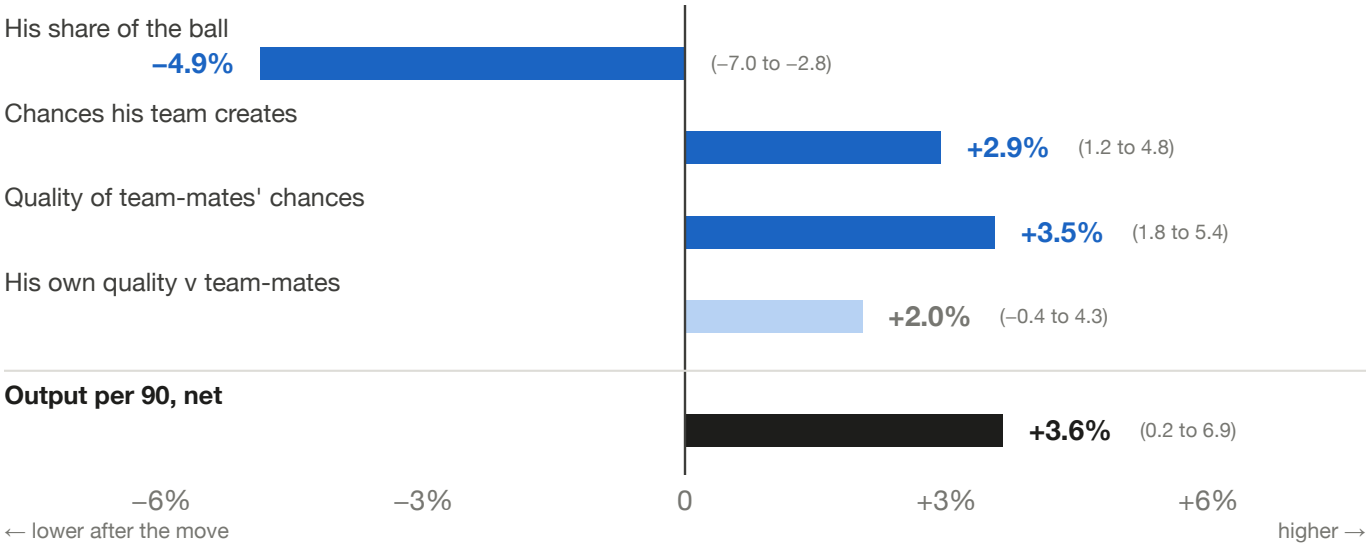
Among attackers who kept a regular place, those who changed club flopped (output per 90 down by more than 25%) 19% of the time, against 18% for those who stayed. If each player's quality against his team-mates had not changed at all, luck alone would give 22%. A typical move trades some of the ball for a better team, and per 90 the player comes out ahead.

19% v 18%
flop rate, moved v stayed

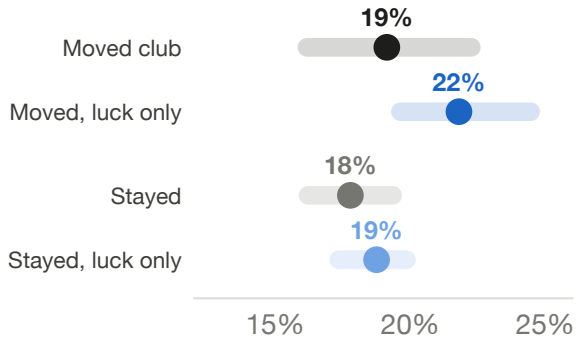
–1.7%
chance quality, 5 points more ball

+0.5%
pair chemistry, second season v first

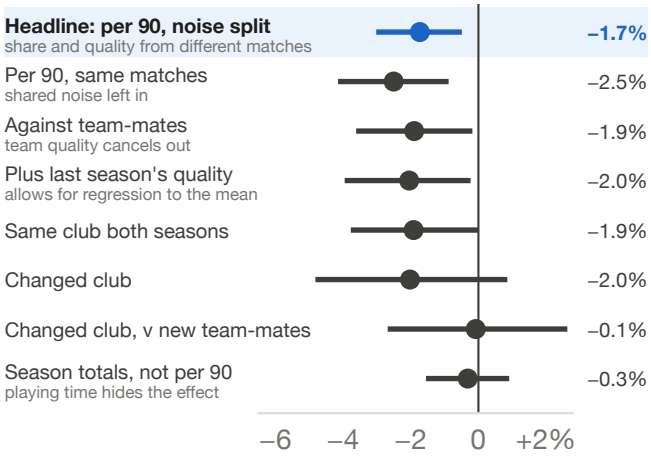
What a typical move does, against players who stayed (per 90)



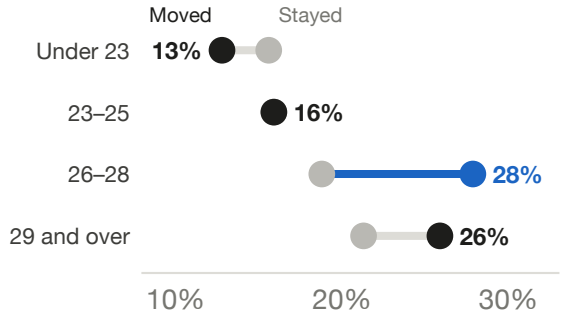
Flop rates against luck alone



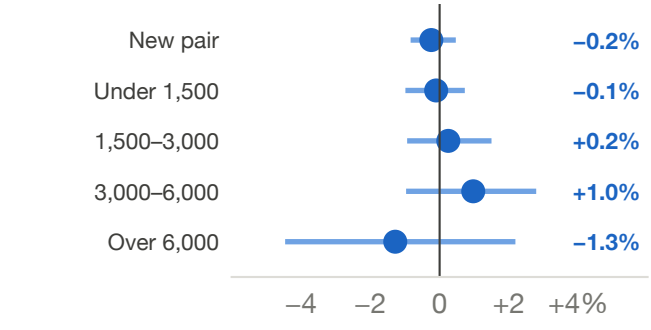
Same player, 5 points more of the ball



Flop rate by age: moved v stayed



Chemistry by minutes already together



Limits: shots and shot-assists only, so it suits attackers; regulars only (900+ minutes in both seasons); observational, so it shows patterns, not causes. Data: Understat xG; Transfermarkt line-ups and substitutions. Intervals are 95% and resample whole players.

github.com/benedictprimmer-web/football-usage-efficiency